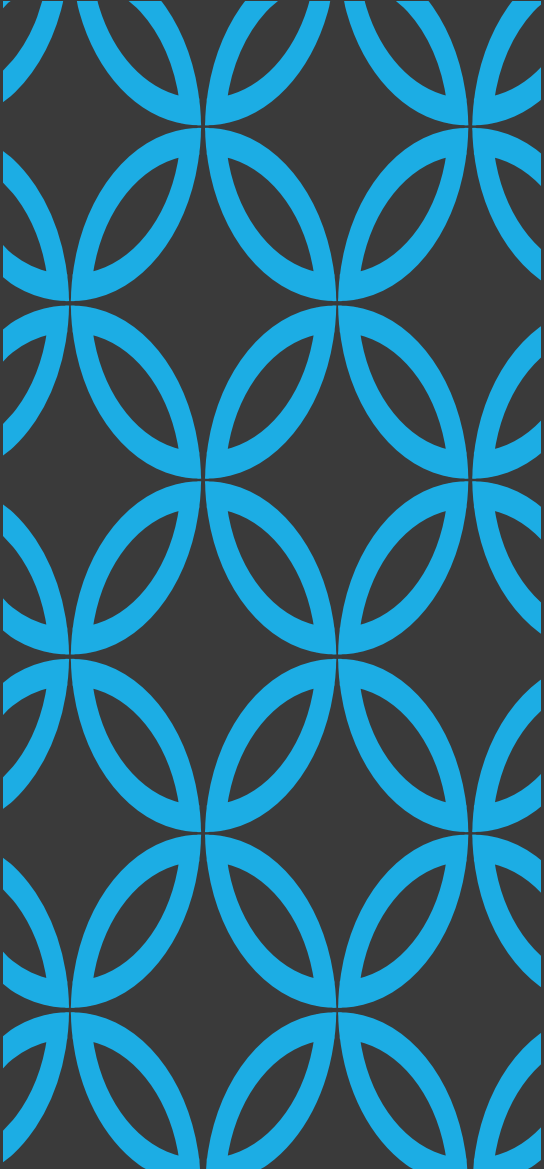




CRITICAL GEOPOLITICS, FRAME ANALYSIS, AND SECOND-ORDER OBSERVATION

Session: The Collaboration between First-Order and
Second-Order Observations

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5th ISA Forum of Sociology

Rabat, Morocco

2025

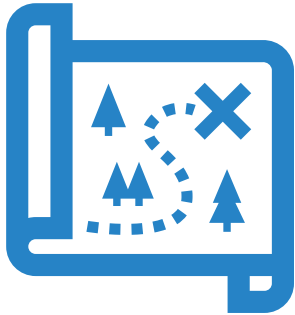
INTRODUCTION: THREE THEORETICAL DEVICES

- Critical Geopolitics (Dodds): Power relations that frame geopolitical realities.

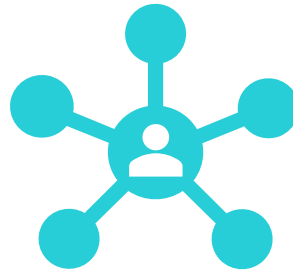
- Frame Analysis (Goffman): How experience is organized by frames.

- Second-Order Observation (Luhmann): Observing how Alter (an other) observes, i.e., the use of latent structures.

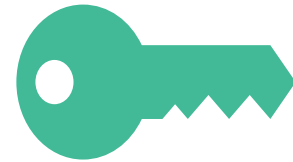
TRADITIONAL VS. CRITICAL GEOPOLITICS (DODDS)



Traditional:
Sovereignty,
deterrence,
cartography.



Critical: Networks,
power
configurations,
discourse.



Who defines
the state of the
world?

CLASSICAL / CRITICAL

(Classical) geopolitics treats geography and state power as fixed bases of international relations – a *realist view of nations competing* for territory, security, and influence.

Critical geopolitics notes that such a realist approach towards geopolitics tends to **naturalize** and legitimize these power struggles as inevitable, *obscuring the ideological assumptions (latent frames)* behind them .

WHY CRITICAL GEOPOLITICS?

Critical geopolitics enables a reflexive look at geopolitics: not just *what* is happening, but *how* it is observed and communicated, oscillating between direct “first-order” perspectives and reflective “second-order” analyses.

Critical geopolitics seeks to “*disenchant*” classical geopolitics by denaturalizing its concepts – revealing how ideas like East/West, North/South, Center/Periphery, friend/enemy, or even maps of spheres of influence are products of *preconstructed historical and ideological frames, not immutable truths* .

WHY CRITICAL GEOPOLITICS?

Critical Geopolitics challenges the classical assumption that geography or fate alone determine world politics, instead showing how leaders and cultures *impose meaning* on geography (for example, seeing one's country as an “island of freedom” vs. an “iron curtain” on the map).

By highlighting the role of power, representations and discourse, critical geopolitics opens space for alternative visions *beyond the zero-sum, state-as-ego-actor mindset* – **potentially pointing toward more cooperative geopolitical imaginaries.**

THREE LEVELS OF GEOPOLITICS (DODDS)

**First and Second-Order Observations
coexist, collaborate, co-emerge.**



FORMAL:
SCHOLARS,
ACADEMICS.



PRACTICAL:
POLICYMAKERS,
STRATEGISTS.



POPULAR: MEDIA,
POP CULTURE.

**Re-descriptions of several ways of seeing
and critiques of framing operations.**

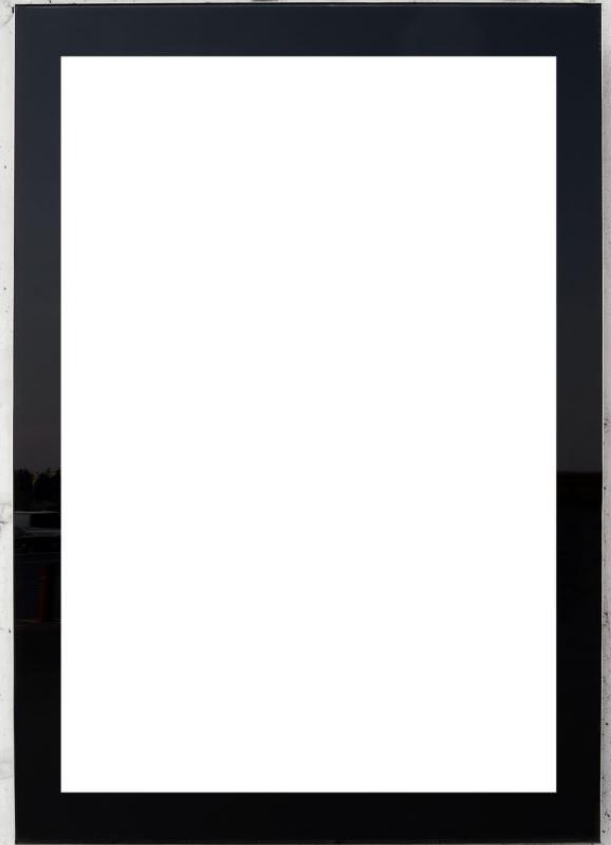
WHAT IS A FRAME? (GOFFMAN)

A “**frame**” is a schema that enables interpretation – it highlights certain aspects of reality while filtering out others, *even before an observation begins.*

Frames are used to make sense of complex information, *even before starting to observe.*

In media and politics, frames define “what the issue is” and “what the story is about”. By pre-labeling events in particular ways, frames assign meaning: they tell audiences *which facts matter, who is hero or villain, what is at stake, and what solutions are conceivable.*

Frames are latent structures that can (or not) be brought to light (become manifest).



WHY FRAMING MATTERS IN GEOPOLITICS

- Frames shape *spaces of possibilities* and descriptions (stories being told).

Examples:

- **Migration:**

'Humanitarian Crisis' or 'Alien Invasion'.

- **Energy:**

'Security' or 'Sovereignty' or 'Transition'.

- **Supply Chains:**

'Decoupling' or 'Derisking' or 'Friendshoring'

- **AI:**

'future of work' or 'catastrophic loss of jobs'



SECOND-ORDER OBSERVATION (LUHMANN)

How mass media
operates?
How the system
observes geopolitically?



We see the world
through how others
(systems) observe it.



Mass media are
second-order
observers.



Who is describing
reality, addressed
to whom and how?

THE STABILIZATION OF DOUBLE CONTINGENCY (KEYNESIAN CONTEST)

“It is not a case of choosing those [faces] which, to the best of one’s judgment, are really the prettiest, nor even those which average opinion genuinely thinks the prettiest. **We have reached the third degree where we devote our intelligences to anticipating what average opinion expects the average opinion to be. And there are some, I believe, who practise the fourth, fifth and higher degrees.**” — John Maynard Keynes, *The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money* (1936)

THE KEYNESIAN BEAUTY CONTEST

First-order: I choose what *I* find prettiest.

Second-order: I choose what I expect *the majority* will find prettiest.

Third-order: I choose what I think the majority expects *the majority to think* is prettiest.

This beautifully captures the essence of double-contingency and higher-order reasoning in social systems.

This is the level at which mass media operate.

EXAMPLE 'LIBERATION DAY' TARIFFS

2025: Broad tariffs framed as emancipation.

Many intended simultaneous uses: Retaliation, source of wealth, dealmaking, reciprocity.



A MISFRAMED ECONOMIC STRATEGY

- Tariffs as an attempt to ‘rebalance’ trade as a matter of ‘national emergency’.
- Framed using a *zero-sum* logic of interconnectedness—*implying that one nation’s gain in trade must necessarily be another’s loss (“They are ripping us off”)*. Analysts widely criticized this logic as fundamentally incompatible with the *mutual dependencies of global trade systems, where interlinked value chains generate co-evolutionary gains, not binary outcomes.*
- Arbitrarily recycling the latent distinction of *dealmaking* and transposing it onto the complex economic system.
- Even the *formulas* used to justify the tariffs (e.g., simplified trade deficits and wins/losses) were immediately criticized as logically flawed and analytically incoherent.



OBSERVING THE OBSERVERS

Geopolitical analysts pointed out the weaponization of a trade-as-war logic.

EU framed it as a breach of the global trade order.

Economists warned of self-harm.

FRAME CONTESTS IN MEDIA

the administration offered the “Liberation” frame; economists and media offered a “protectionism backfires” frame (noting tariffs are effectively a tax on Americans and a breach of global norms).

initial news report the announcement (first-order), subsequent analysis debates the wisdom and meaning of it (second-order).



First-order: Offer official narratives: ‘Liberation Day’



Second-order: Media critique OR First-order reproduction.



Public perception shaped in between: oscillating between frames.



PRESIDENTIAL ACTIONS

PROTECTING THE AMERICAN PEOPLE AGAINST INVASION

The White House | January 20, 2025

PROTECTING THE AMERICAN PEOPLE AGAINST INVASION

By the authority vested in me as President by the Constitution and the laws of the United States of America, including the Immigration and Nationality Act (INA) (8 U.S.C. 1101 *et seq.*) and section 301 of title 3, United States Code, it is hereby ordered:

ANOTHER EXAMPLE

A frame-analytic lens would encourage us to ask: Why this wording? What alternative descriptions are omitted? Who benefits from this framing?

Reflexive exercise —a **second-order observation** on narratives (observing not just events, but how observers describe events) and examining *the discursive strategies used to narrativize actions*.

LAST EXAMPLE: AI REGULATION

If methodical second-order observation is applied, actors can become more conscious of existing reinforcing loops and choose to alter their framing of experience.

For example, instead of framing AI development purely as an arms race (“whoever leads will dominate”), major powers could frame it as a mutual risk (“uncontrolled AI is a threat to all”) – a shift in frame that could create a positive feedback loop of cooperation, trust-building, and jointly accepted rules.

There are efforts in AI regulation discussions where countries acknowledge the need of shared standards – an example of a step toward a common interest reframing in a specific domain.



CONCLUSION: FROM LATENT STRUCTURES TO REFRAMING POSSIBILITIES

By identifying frames, we open the possibility to **reframe** – to challenge dominant narratives and consider alternative perspectives.

In Goffman's terms, one can perform “*keying*” or re-interpretation of a situation, essentially changing its meaning by shifting the frame.

This is particularly useful for **advancing critical geopolitics** because it introduces reflexivity.

Rather than taking national myths or strategic doctrines at face value, frame analysis encourages a step back to see them as *latent yet constructed stories that are open to further development or structural drift*.

APPLY FRAME ANALYSIS TO SHIFT FROM LATENCIES
TO VISIBLE STRUCTURES.



Observe second-order mechanisms of stabilization
between first and second-order chains of
observations, decisions and expectations.



UNDERSTAND HOW NARRATIVES FORM.

REFRAMING GEOPOLITICAL ANALYSIS DOING SOCIOCYBERNETICS

Shared
challenges
need
reframing
shared frames.

From Mutual
Assured
Disruption to
Mutual
Assured
Development?

REFRAMING THE FUTURE

Critical geopolitics, by questioning the nation-state's egoistic assumptions, allows imagining forms of politics that acknowledge mutual dependence and shared destiny. If we continually and consciously oscillate between first and second-order observations, we might avoid the traps of both naive idealism and cynical realism.

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THANK YOU

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